

Does the ZEIT Hormuz reportage hold up?

Mahsa Azad's reportage "*Früher kamen die Teheraner Hippies auf die Delfin-Insel, heute: Stille*" (DIE ZEIT, 27 September 2026, photos by Hashem Shakeri) describes a closed strait, ships waiting at anchor, a grounded Thai freighter and oil on the beaches of Qeshm. This report tests each checkable statement against satellite imagery, ship-tracking data and independent reporting.

Sentinel-1 radar: 237 passes, Sep 2025 – Sep 2026

Sentinel-2 optical imagery

IMF PortWatch AIS transits

News reporting, collected 27 Sep 2026

Short answer. Satellites can't check a reportage's conversations, but they can test its factual scaffolding, and that holds up well. The claims a satellite can test directly are plainly visible. Traffic through the strait collapsed on 1 March while ships queue on both sides. A bulk carrier has sat on the beach near Ramchah since 28 March. Oil appears off Naghasheh on 10 August.

Three details are wrong or unsupported. News reports connect the oil to a Liberian-flagged, Greek-managed ship, not to an Emirati one. No report says the Revolutionary Guards seized the Thai ship. The Minab school had boys among its pupils and dead, so it was not only a girls' school. The ceasefire timeline is also more complicated than "the July ceasefire".

✓ Confirmed

8 claims

● Right, detail off

2

● Partly right

3

✗ Refuted

0

-95%

Hormuz transits, Aug 2026 vs Aug 2025 (146 vs 2,930, AIS)

19 → 4

large ships per radar pass in the strait's lanes (medians, before vs Jul-Sep)

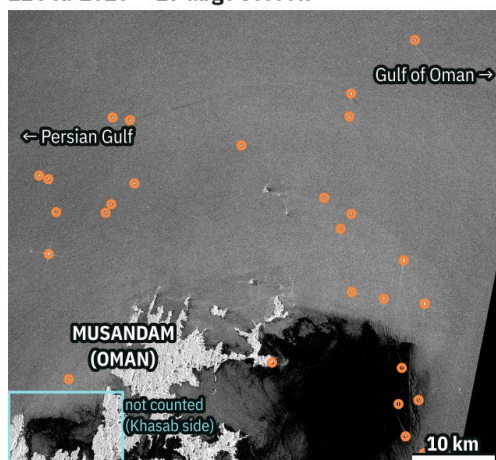
131 → 256

large ships at the Fujairah anchorage, before the war vs 16 Sep

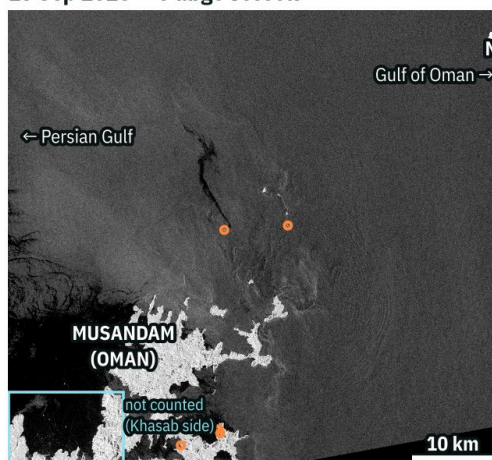
180 days

the Thai freighter has sat on the Ramchah beach in Sentinel-2 images (28 Mar – 24 Sep)

22 Feb 2026 · 27 large vessels



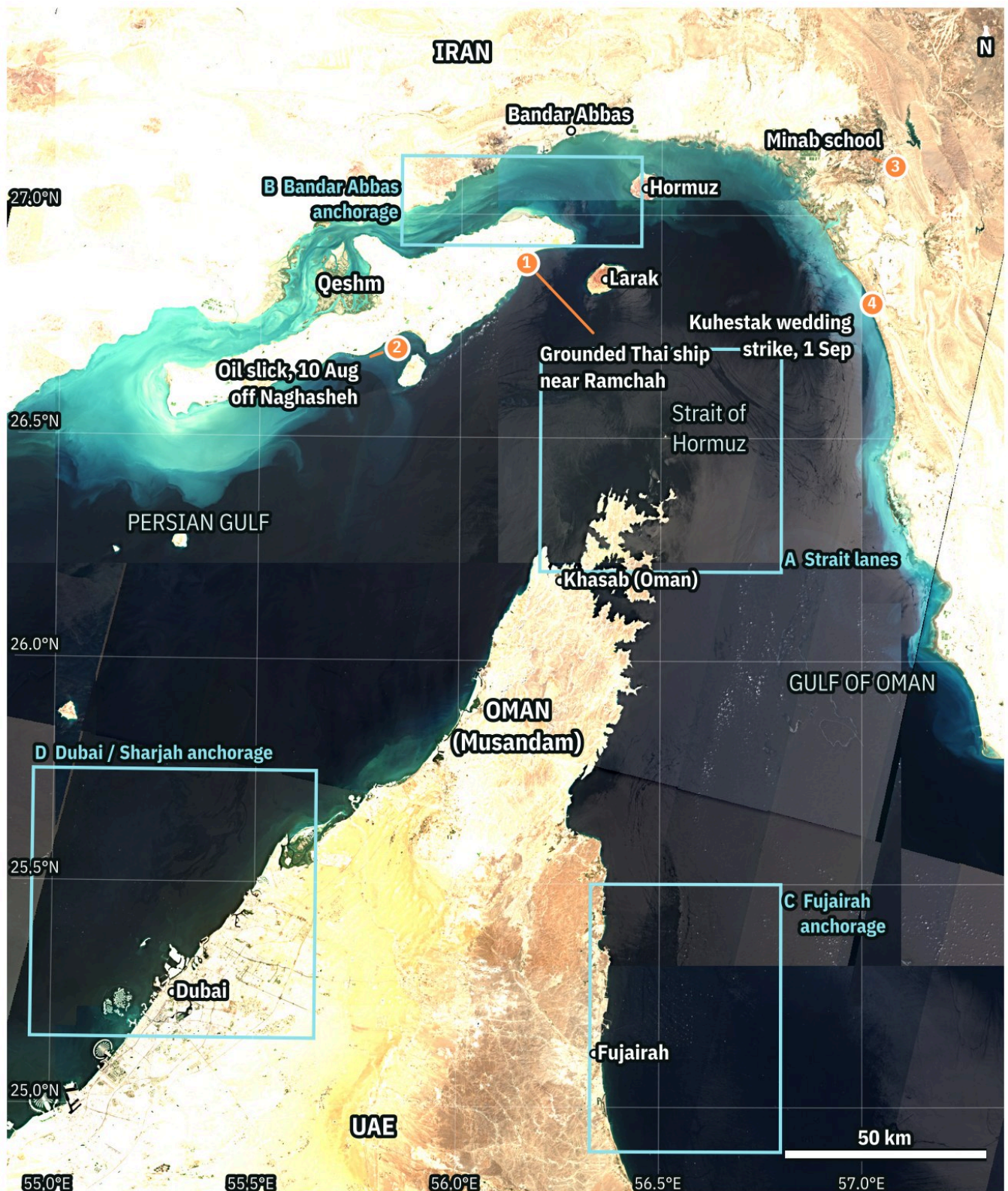
13 Sep 2026 · 6 large vessels



The strait's shipping lanes seen by Sentinel-1 radar, 22 February vs 13 September 2026. Orange circles: large vessels (27 before the war, 6 now). Details on pages 6–11. All satellite images: Copernicus Sentinel data 2025–2026, processed and annotated for this report; orange marks are annotations, not features in the data.

WHERE

The places in the article



Sentinel-2 true-colour mosaic, August–September 2026, 150 m resolution. Numbered markers show the evidence locations; cyan boxes are the four areas where Sentinel-1 radar was used to count ships. Seams between satellite passes are visible over water.

- | | |
|---|--|
| 1 Grounded Thai ship near Ramchah, Qeshm (Evidence 3) | ☐ A · Strait shipping lanes |
| 2 Oil slick off Naghasheh, 10 Aug (Evidence 4) | ☐ B · Bandar Abbas / Qeshm anchorage (the ferry crossing) |
| 3 Shajareh Tayyebah school, Minab | ☐ C · Fujairah anchorage, outside the strait |
| 4 Kuhestak, wedding strike 1 Sep | ☐ D · Dubai / Sharjah anchorage, inside the Gulf |

Thirteen checkable statements

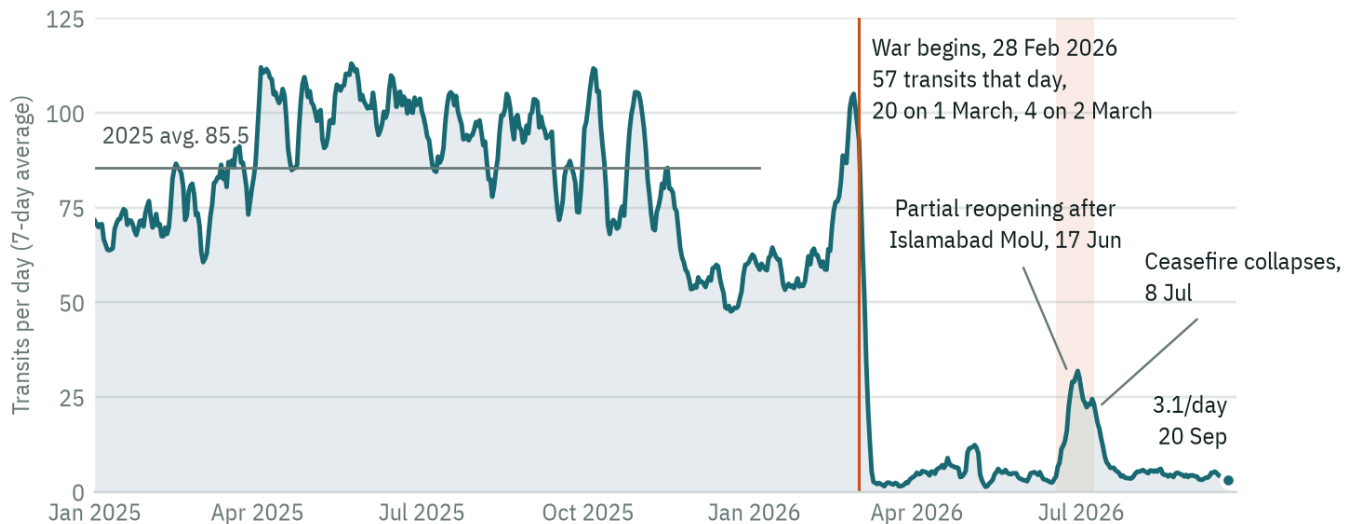
Quotes from the article. “Own analysis” means measured from satellite or ship-tracking data for this report.

CLAIM IN THE ARTICLE	VERDICT	WHAT THE EVIDENCE SHOWS
The strait has been largely closed to shipping since the US war on Iran began (28 Feb). <i>„bleibt seit Beginn des US-Krieges ... weitgehend geschlossen“</i>	✓ Confirmed	AIS transits fell from 85 a day in 2025 to 20 on 1 March and 4 on 2 March. They have averaged 4.4 a day since August (–95%). Radar, which also sees ships with transponders off, shows large vessels in the lanes down about 80% (median 19 → 3–4 per pass). There was a short partial reopening in late June. OWN ANALYSIS · PORTWATCH, SENTINEL-1 · P. 5–7
Many ships lie at anchor; “the whole world is waiting”. <i>„Schiffe über Schiffe vor Anker“ · „Die ganze Welt wartet.“</i>	✓ Confirmed	Off Bandar Abbas and Qeshm, radar still shows 40–61 large vessels in every pass since April, against a median of 77 before the war. The queues are on the far sides of the strait. At Fujairah (Gulf of Oman) large vessels rose to 213 on average in Jul–Sep and a record 256 on 16 Sep. Off Dubai/Sharjah they roughly doubled in spring (median 116 in May–Jun vs 59). The IMO put stranded ships at about 2,000 on 21 April. OWN ANALYSIS · SENTINEL-1 · NEWS · P. 8–11
A Thai-flagged ship was hit, seized by the IRGC and ran aground near Ramchah, opposite Larak island.	🕒 Right, detail off	Sentinel-2 shows a bulk carrier with five hatch covers on the shore at 26.892°N 56.162°E in every clear image from 28 March to 24 September; absent on 18 March. Reporting names it the <i>Mayuree Naree</i> (IMO 9323649), hit on 11 March, adrift, aground on 27 March and written off in August. No source found for an IRGC seizure. OWN ANALYSIS · SENTINEL-2 · NEWS · P. 12
Naghasheh beach is covered in black oil from an Iranian hit on an Emirati ship. <i>„mit einem schwarzen Ölfilm überzogen ... Treffer auf ein emiratisches Schiff“</i>	🕒 Partly right	Sentinel-2 on 10 August shows thick oil ribbons and emulsion 4–6 km off Naghasheh, between Qeshm and Hengam. None on 26 July; mostly dispersed by 25 August. Iran’s environment agency reported oil on this coast. Reporting traces the slick to the <i>Minoan Pioneer</i> (Liberian flag, Greek-managed), hit around 3 August, not to an Emirati ship. The source is not officially confirmed. Dead mangroves and crabs are too small for 10 m imagery. OWN ANALYSIS · SENTINEL-2 · NEWS · P. 13
A US airstrike hit the girls’ school in Minab on 28 February, the first day of the war. <i>„die Mädchenschule, die dort am 28. Februar ... getroffen wurde“</i>	🕒 Right, detail off	Extensively documented: 156 dead according to Amnesty and Wikipedia’s count. CENTCOM’s preliminary finding cites outdated target data; a UN mission found “reasonable grounds” for a war crime. OpenStreetMap labels the building a girls’ primary school, but boys and girls were among the dead. The “20 IRGC daughters” figure is unsourced (the article calls it rumour). Sentinel-2 at 10 m shows no measurable change. NEWS · SENTINEL-2 INCONCLUSIVE · P. 15
No shelling of Tehran since the July ceasefire; fighting goes on around Hormuz. <i>„Seit der Waffenruhe vom Juli“</i>	🕒 Partly right	A formal ceasefire began 8 April and collapsed 8 July. US strikes reached the Tehran area around 16 July, then a mutual pause from about 25 July. No strikes on Tehran reported since. In the south, US strikes hit Larak on 30 August, 1 and 8 September. NEWS · P. 14

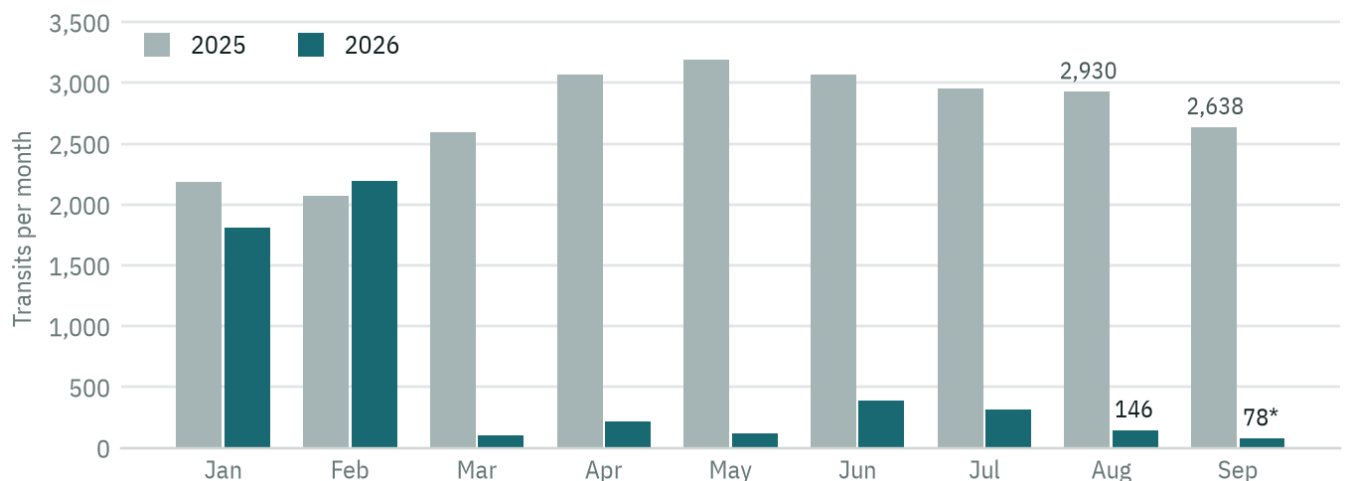
CLAIM IN THE ARTICLE	VERDICT	WHAT THE EVIDENCE SHOWS
Iran fired on the UAE and Kuwait at the start of the war because they host US bases.	✓ Confirmed	Both hit from 28 February, including Al Dhafra (UAE), Ali Al Salem and Camp Buehring (Kuwait). NEWS
Flights to Bandar Abbas were cut and have only recently resumed.	✓ Confirmed	Reopened 5 July after four months, interrupted again; scheduled domestic flights from 15 August. NEWS
Port facilities heavily damaged; big factories and ports around Bandar Abbas shut.	🟡 Partly right	Strikes reported on Bandar Abbas port (2 March), Shahid Haghani port (1 April) and the Panj-Peleh pier (July). Shahid Rajaei barely operating under the blockade. No source found for strikes on the large plants near Bandar Abbas. Radar: about 27% fewer large vessels off the city than before the war. NEWS · OWN ANALYSIS
Many fishing boats hit, fishermen killed.	✓ Confirmed	Iran's judiciary: 12 Hormozgan fishermen killed, 420 boats damaged (state media). Drop Site estimates about 300 boats destroyed. A US drone destroyed two boats off Larak on 14 September. NEWS
The day after the author's return, a US strike hit a wedding in a coastal village she had visited, killing five.	✓ Confirmed	Kuhestak, Sirik county, 1 September: five killed, CENTCOM review ordered. A photo caption in the article is set at Kohestak beach. The IRGC then fired at US bases in Jordan, Bahrain and Iraq. NEWS
Anti-regime protests in January.	✓ Confirmed	Protests from 28 December 2025, peaking in January with an internet shutdown; thousands killed. NEWS
Galloping inflation; prices jump overnight.	✓ Confirmed	Annual inflation 84–89% in August–September; the rial went from about 1.35 million to 2.1–2.4 million per dollar between March and early September. NEWS

Traffic through the strait stopped on 1 March

IMF PortWatch counts cargo ships and tankers crossing the Strait of Hormuz from their AIS transponder signals. The collapse is abrupt: 57 transits on 28 February, 20 on 1 March, 4 on 2 March. Apart from a few weeks around the June memorandum, traffic has stayed near zero since.



Daily transits through the Strait of Hormuz, 7-day average, January 2025 – 20 September 2026. Shaded: partial reopening between the Islamabad memorandum (17 June) and the collapse of the ceasefire (8 July). Source: IMF PortWatch, Daily Chokepoint Transit Calls.



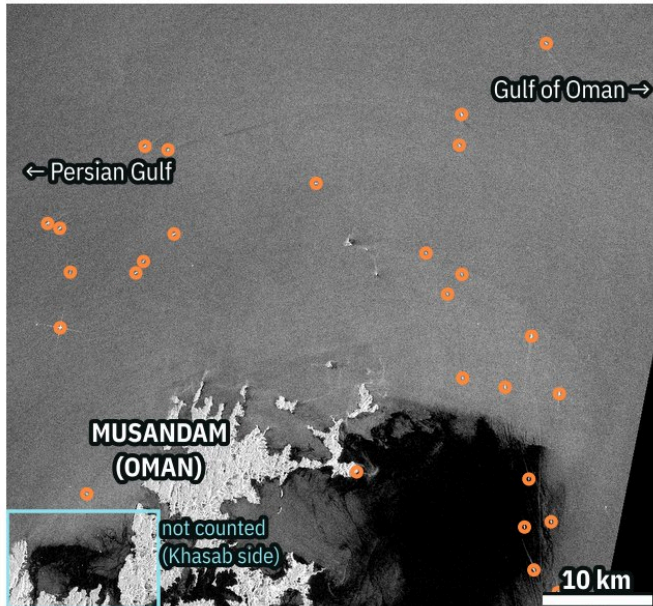
Transits per month, 2025 vs 2026. March–August 2026: 1,285 transits, against 17,809 in March–August 2025 (~93%). *September 2026 covers 1–20 September only. The February 2026 bar includes a pre-war rush in the last two weeks of the month.

Limitation. AIS can be switched off, and ships in a war zone often do so. That is why the next section counts ships with radar, which does not depend on what ships broadcast.

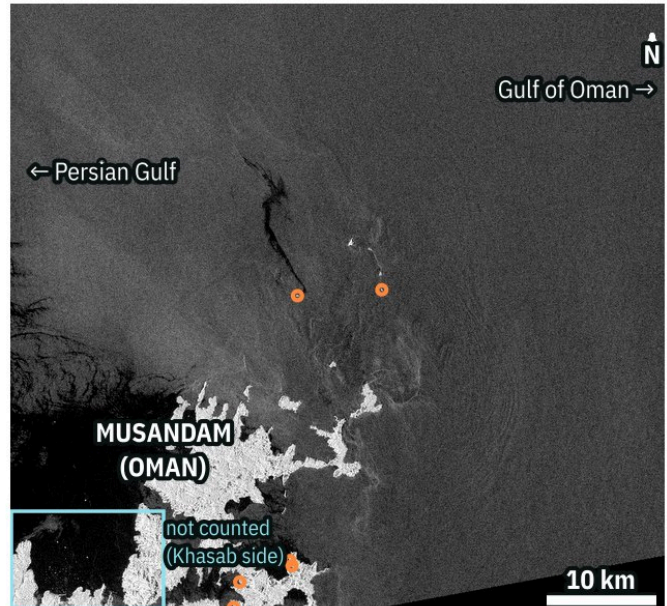
An empty strait, seen by radar

Sentinel-1 radar images the sea day and night, through haze and cloud. Steel hulls return strong echoes and show up as bright points on dark water, whether or not a ship broadcasts AIS. I ran a ship detector over 237 passes between September 2025 and September 2026 in four areas (map, p. 2). The orange circles mark every “large vessel”: a radar footprint above 10,000 m², which in practice means sizeable merchant ships and tankers.

22 Feb 2026 · 27 large vessels



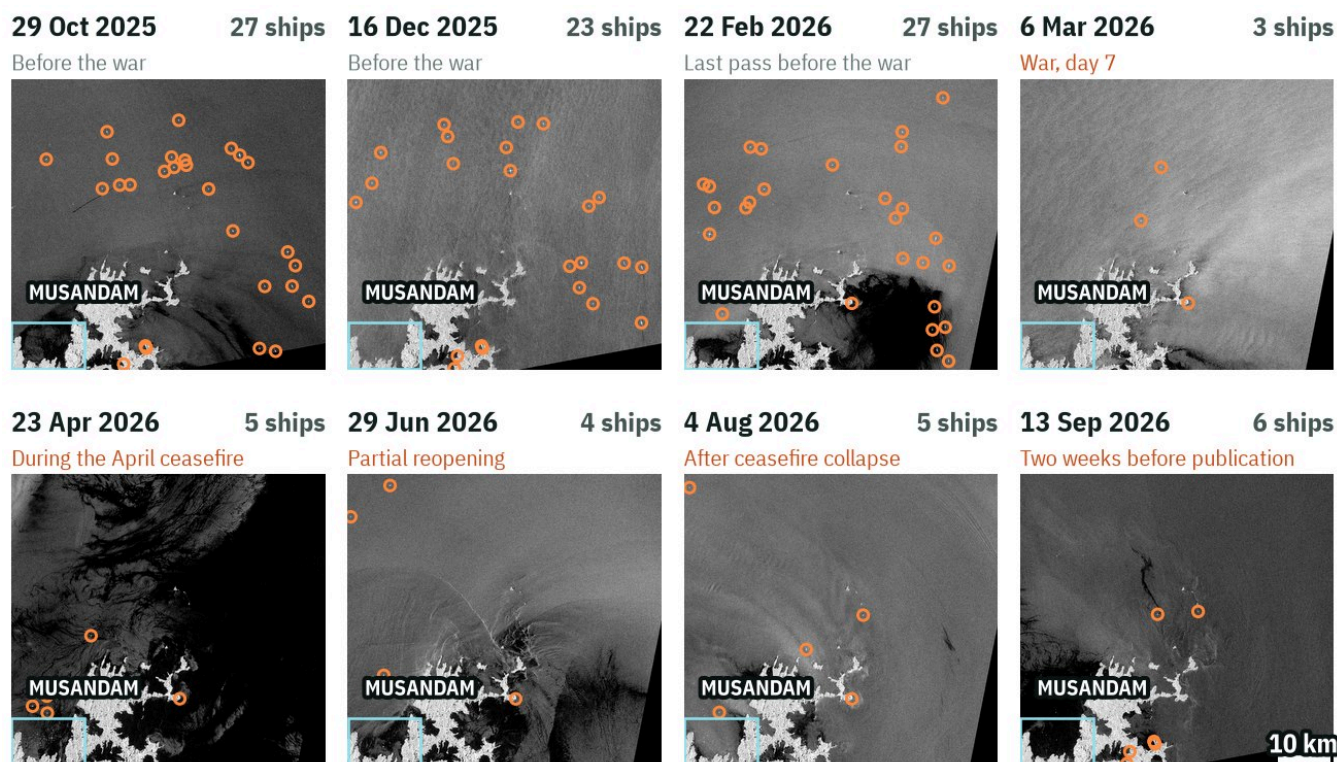
13 Sep 2026 · 6 large vessels



Area A, the strait’s shipping lanes, 22 February vs 13 September 2026 (both Sentinel-1C). The last pass before the war shows 27 large vessels spread along the lanes; 29 weeks later there are 6. The cyan corner near Khasab (Oman) is excluded from all counts because it is crowded with small boats whose identity radar cannot establish. The dark curving streak in the September image is a surface film, possibly oil, and was not analysed.

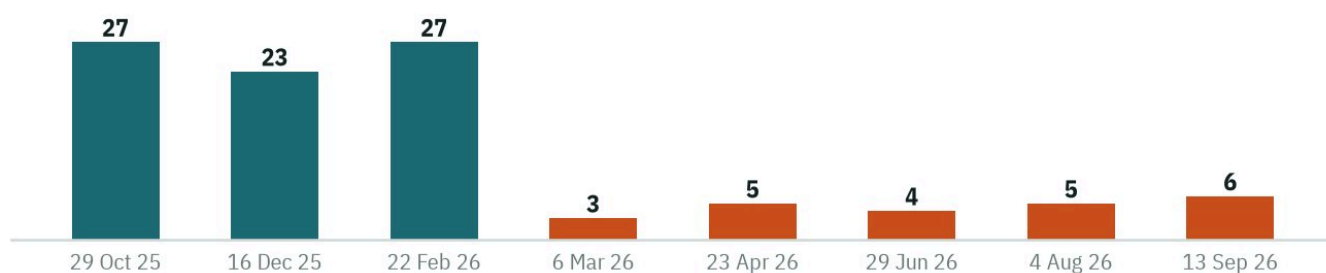
Area A · The shipping lanes, month by month

Eight passes by the same satellite, from October 2025 to September 2026. Before the war a single pass caught 7–27 large vessels in the lanes (median 19). One week into the war there are 3. The count has not recovered since, not even during the April ceasefire or the partial reopening in late June.



Large vessels counted in each image

■ before the war ■ during the war



Sentinel-1C radar, VV polarisation, 60 m display resolution. Each image covers 56.20–56.80°E, 26.20–26.70°N (about 60 × 55 km). Orange circles: large vessels detected automatically. Bars: count per image; teal before the war, orange during it.

Area B · Bandar Abbas: thinner, but still full of ships

This is the water the reporters crossed on the ferry to Qeshm, describing „*lauter ankernde Schiffe*“. The anchorage in front of Bandar Abbas and Shahid Rajaee port holds a half to two-thirds of the roughly 90 large vessels that lay here in the last months before the war. With 40–61 large vessels in every pass since April, it is still crowded with anchored ships, as the article says.

22 Dec 2025

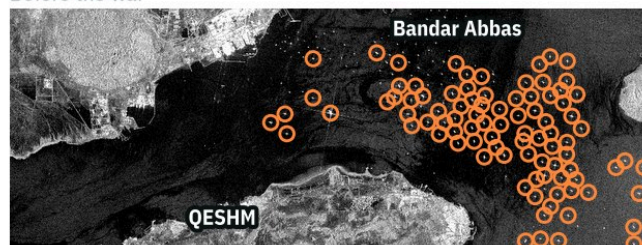
Before the war



92 ships

10 Feb 2026

Before the war



91 ships

9 Apr 2026

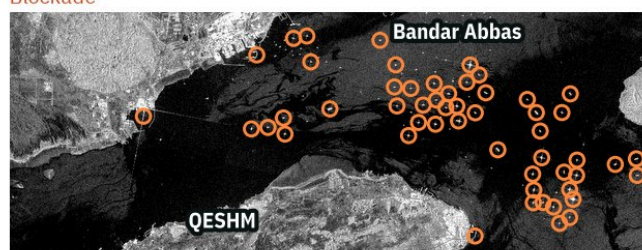
War, week 6



48 ships

29 May 2026

Blockade



53 ships

3 Jul 2026

After ceasefire collapse



43 ships

26 Aug 2026

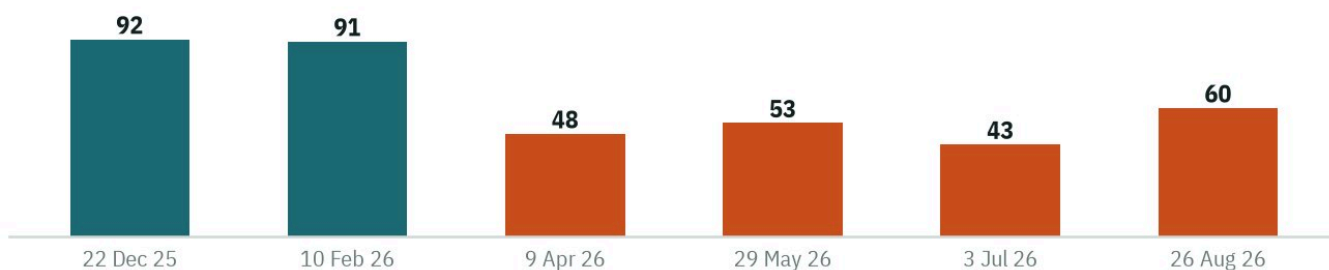
Late Aug, around the reporters' trip



60 ships

Large vessels counted in each image

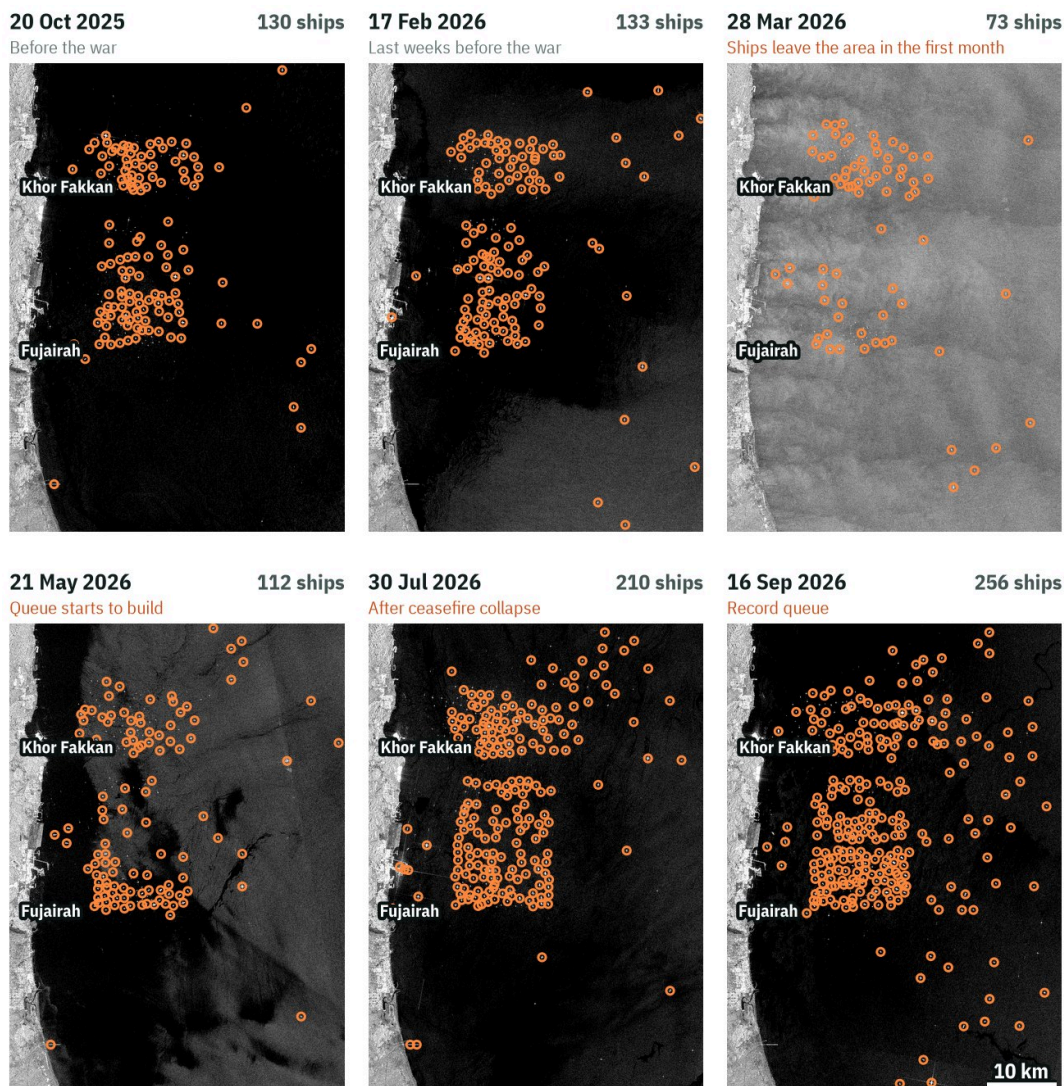
■ before the war ■ during the war



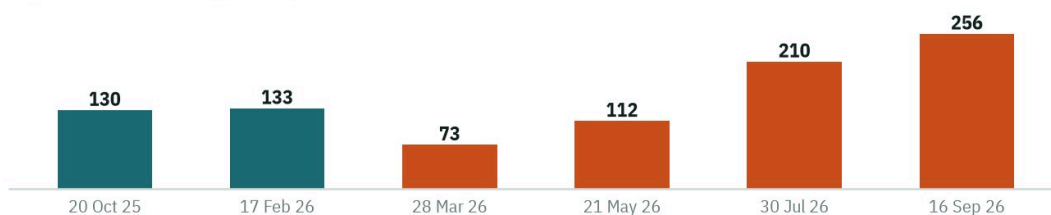
Sentinel-1 radar, waters between Bandar Abbas and Qeshm (55.85–56.45°E, 26.93–27.13°N). Iranian-flagged ships often sail without AIS, so radar is the more reliable way to count them here.

Area C · Fujairah: the queue outside the strait

Fujairah and Khor Fakkan, on the UAE's Gulf of Oman coast, are where ships wait before entering the Gulf. In the first month of the war fewer ships waited here (73 large vessels on 28 March). From May the queue grows. By September the anchorage holds almost twice as many large vessels as before the war, spilling far beyond the usual anchoring grounds. This is what the woman on the Qeshm ferry meant: „*Die ganze Welt wartet.*“



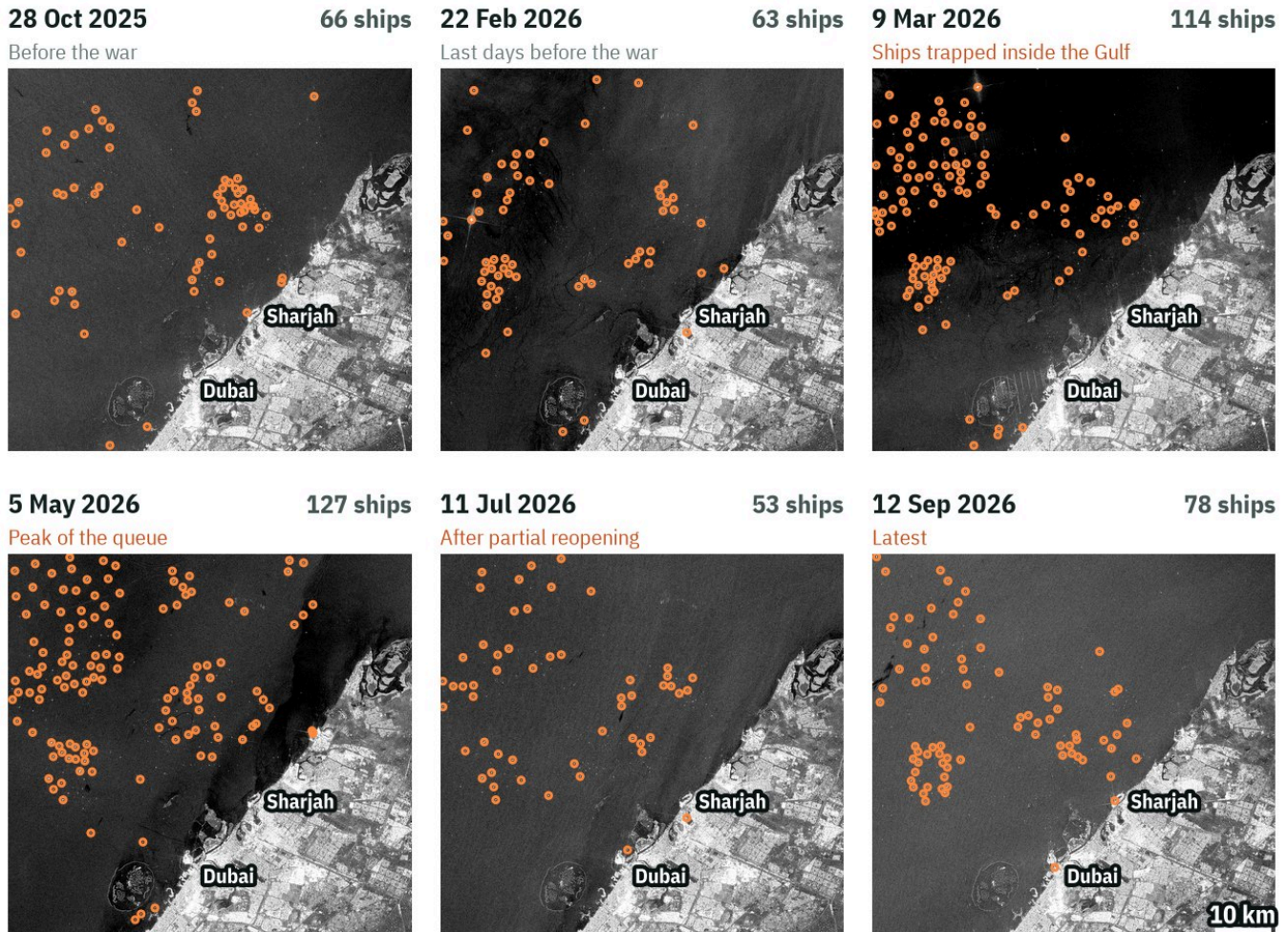
Large vessels counted in each image
■ before the war ■ during the war



Sentinel-1 radar, Fujairah / Khor Fakkan anchorage (56.33–56.80°E, 24.90–25.50°N). Record count on 16 September 2026: 256 large vessels, against 107–145 per pass in autumn 2025.

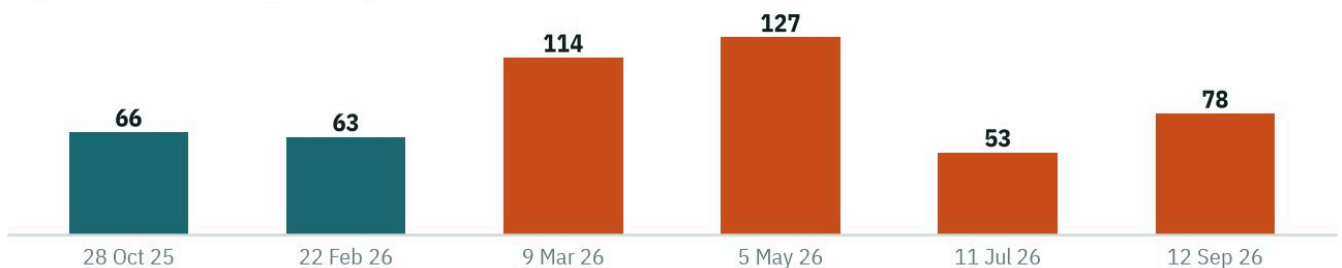
Area D · Dubai and Sharjah: ships trapped inside the Gulf

On the Gulf side, ships that could not leave piled up off Dubai and Sharjah. The count jumps within ten days of the war's start and peaks in May at twice the pre-war level. It falls back after the partial reopening in late June, when some ships got out.



Large vessels counted in each image

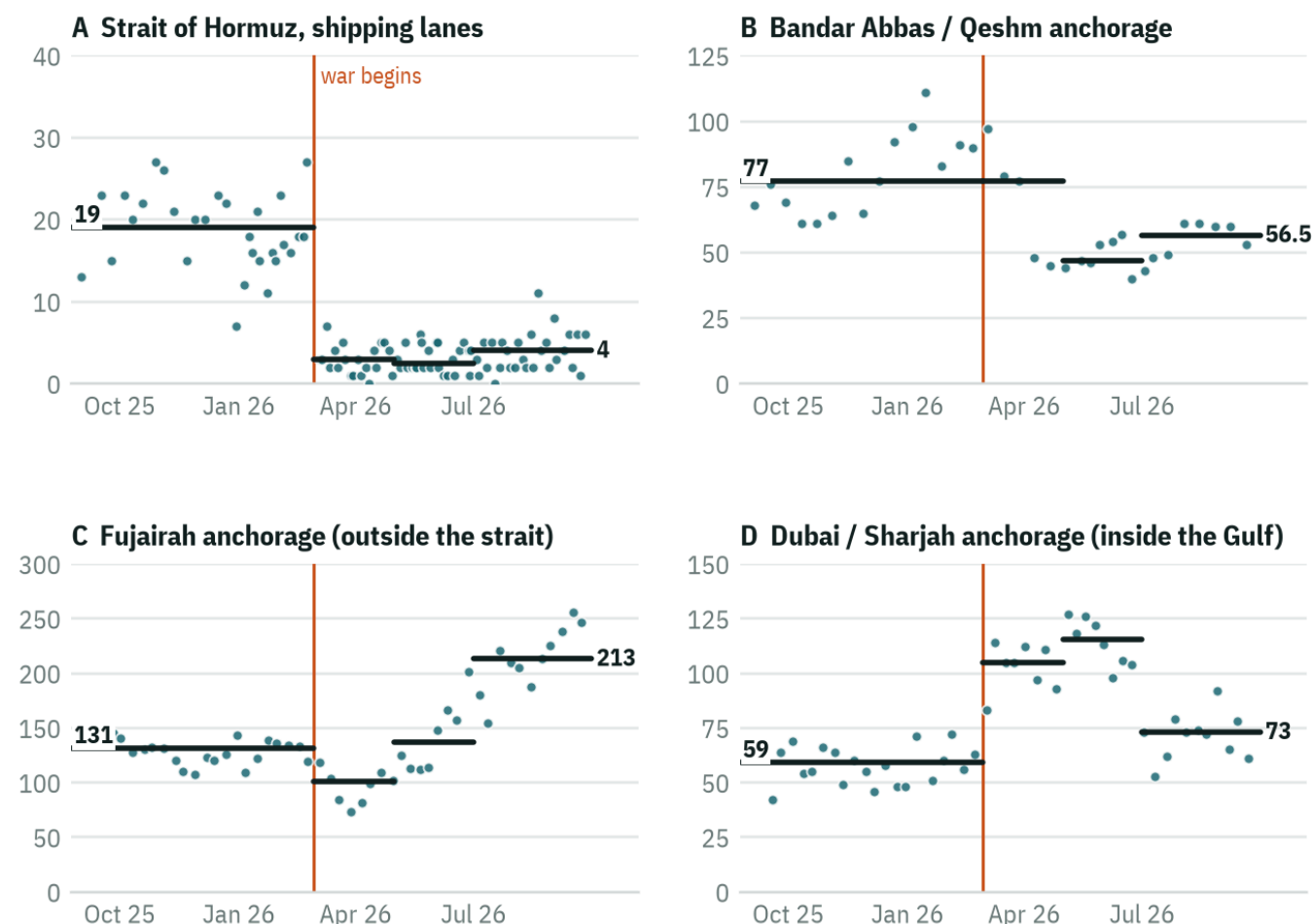
before the war during the war



Sentinel-1 radar, Dubai / Sharjah anchorage (54.95–55.65°E, 25.15–25.75°N). Harbour basins and marinas are masked out; only open water more than 160 m from the coast is counted.

Every radar pass, in four charts

The image series above show single days. The charts below show every usable pass, with the median for each period as a black line. The pattern holds across the whole record: the lanes empty, the queues outside and inside grow, and Bandar Abbas thins out.



Large vessels per Sentinel-1 pass, September 2025 – September 2026. Dots: single passes. Lines: period medians (before the war; Mar–Apr; May–Jun; Jul–Sep). Note the different vertical scales.

AREA	BEFORE THE WAR	MAR–APR	MAY–JUN	JUL–SEP	CHANGE
A · Strait shipping lanes	19	3	2.5	4	–79%
B · Bandar Abbas / Qeshm	77	77	47	56.5	–27%
C · Fujairah (outside)	131	100.5	136.5	213	+63%
D · Dubai / Sharjah (inside)	59	105	115.5	73	+24%

Median large vessels per pass. Passes per period: A 30/20/24/29, B 15/5/7/8, C 23/8/8/11, D 22/8/8/11. Before the war = September 2025 to 27 February 2026.

The Thai freighter on the beach at Ramchah

The article's caption places the stricken Thai ship near Ramchah on Qeshm, facing Larak island. Sentinel-2 finds it there: on the island's south-eastern shore, about 3 km from the village and 20 km across the water from Larak.



Sentinel-2, 24 September 2026. Eastern Qeshm with Qeshm town, Ramchah and Larak island.

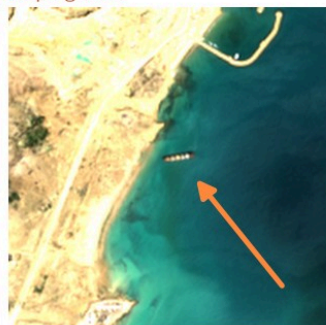
18 Mar 2026

no ship



28 Mar 2026

ship aground



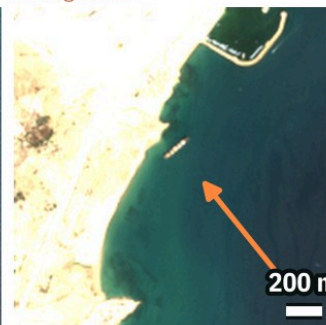
10 Aug 2026

still aground, hull turned



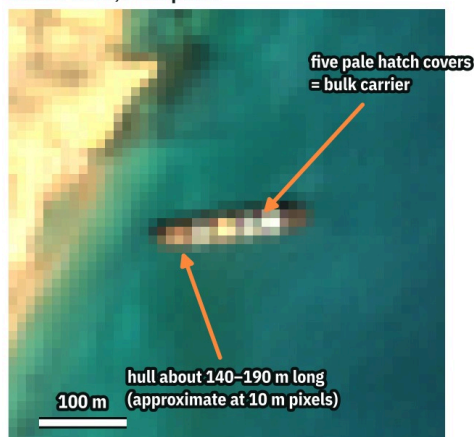
24 Sep 2026

still aground



Sentinel-2, 1.8 × 1.8 km around the wreck. Nothing on 18 March. From 28 March, the day after the reported grounding, a ship lies in the shallows in every clear image through 24 September. Between April and August the hull turns, as a stranded wreck worked by waves does.

28 Mar 2026, 10 m pixels



Identification. The pale blocks along the deck are hatch covers, the signature of a bulk carrier. Five are visible, and the hull is about 140–190 m long at this resolution. Reporting identifies the ship as the *Mayuree Naree* (IMO 9323649, Precious Shipping), a 30,193-dwt bulk carrier. It was hit by two projectiles on 11 March; 20 crew were rescued to Khasab and 3 died. It drifted for about 16 days and grounded on 27 March.

What the images don't show. Who controlled the ship after it was hit. The article says it was seized by the Revolutionary Guards; no report found supports that.

Oil off Naghasheh in August

The author describes Naghasheh beach in the south of Qeshm covered in a black film, with dead mangroves and crab carcasses. The channel between Qeshm and Hengam island is clean on 26 July. On 10 August it holds a large slick, 4–6 km from Naghasheh. By 25 August the surface is clear again, though oil that reached the shore would remain.

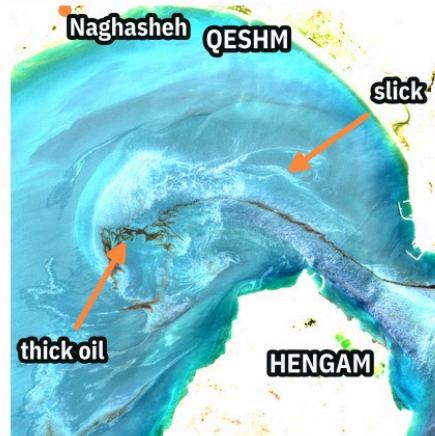
26 Jul 2026

clean water



10 Aug 2026

oil slick



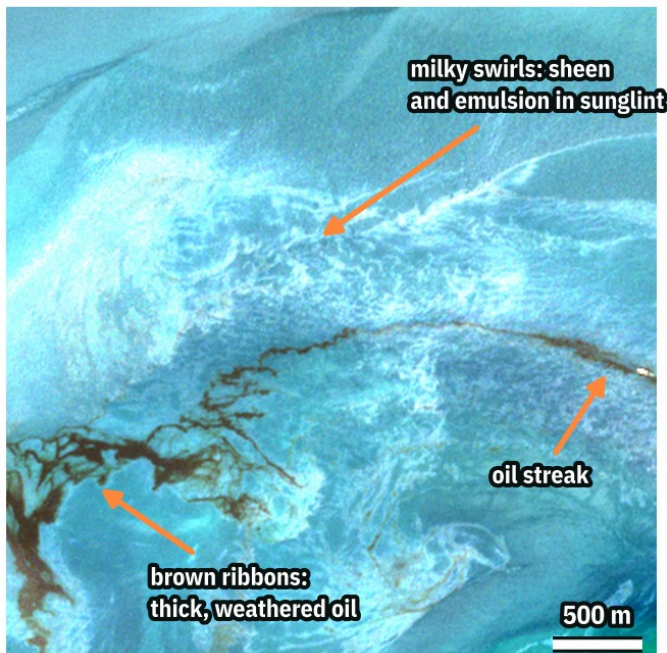
25 Aug 2026

dispersed



Sentinel-2 true colour, 9 × 9 km, contrast stretched for water. Qeshm's south coast at the top, Hengam island at the bottom; Naghasheh marked in orange.

10 Aug 2026, detail



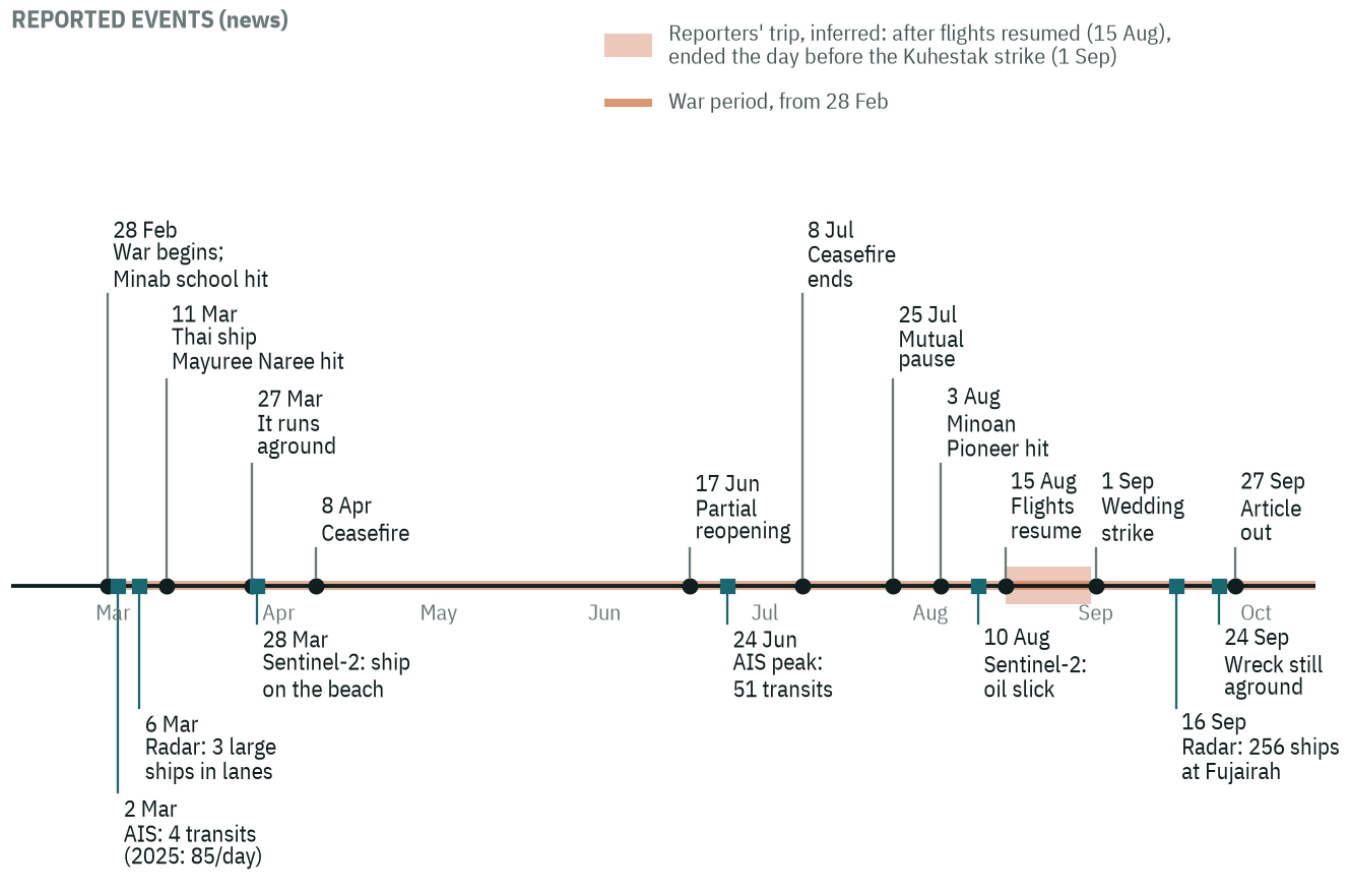
Reading the image. Brown, branching ribbons are typical of thick, emulsified oil; the milky swirls are sheen and emulsion catching the sunglint. Natural algae films rarely look brown and branched like this.

Where it came from. Not visible here. The article blames an Iranian hit on an Emirati ship. News reports (Reuters, citing TankerTrackers) trace the slick to the *Minoan Pioneer*, a Liberian-flagged, Greek-managed ship hit near Khasab around 3 August. Iran's environment department reported 3.2 ha of polluted coast on this stretch.

Timing. The slick on 10 August fits the reporters' trip, which the article places before the 1 September strike at Kuhestak (next page).

The article’s timeline lines up with the data

The reportage gives few dates, but its sequence can be tested. The reporters flew to Bandar Abbas on “one of the first flights” after they resumed (15 August). They saw oil at Naghasheh (in the water on 10 August). A coastal village they had visited was bombed the day after their return: Kuhestak, 1 September, a place named in one of the photo captions. Every datable event in the article fits a trip in the second half of August.



WHAT THE DATA SHOWS (satellite and ship tracking)

Reported events (top) against what the satellite and ship-tracking data show (bottom), February – September 2026.

What this data can't tell you

- **The people.** The quotes, the smuggler Abdol, the unveiled women, the Tehran hippies who no longer come: none of this leaves a trace in public data. It rests on the reporter's and photographer's credibility.
- **The Minab school.** At 10 m resolution a school building is a handful of pixels, and Sentinel-2 shows no measurable change (below). The strike itself rests on reporting that used high-resolution commercial imagery and munitions evidence (Amnesty, HRW, BBC Verify, NYT, CNN).
- **Dead mangroves and crabs, damaged docks, idle factories.** Too small or too slow to measure reliably at this resolution.
- **Iranian ports in AIS data.** PortWatch shows little change at Shahid Rajaei, but many Iranian ships sail with transponders off, so AIS badly undercounts Iranian ports. It was not used as evidence either way.
- **What a radar blip is.** Radar shows vessels, not names. "Large vessels" are counted by size, so warships and big fishing vessels can be included, and ships moored alongside each other can merge. The counts are for comparison over time, not a census.

21 Feb 2026

one week before the strike



18 Mar 2026

18 days after the strike



Sentinel-2 around the Shajareh Tayyebah school, Minab (27.1096°N 57.0848°E, OpenStreetMap), 1 × 1 km. Before and after the 28 February strike. No change can be resolved at 10 m; this is why the verdict on the school rests on reporting, not on this report's own analysis.

How this was checked

Ship tracking. IMF PortWatch “Daily Chokepoint Transit Calls”, Strait of Hormuz, 1 January 2024 – 20 September 2026, from its public ArcGIS service. Counts are cargo ships and tankers identified by AIS.

Radar. Sentinel-1 radiometrically terrain-corrected backscatter from Microsoft Planetary Computer, VV polarisation, read at 20 m. At most one pass every 6 days per area, only passes covering at least 85% of the area. A ship is a cluster of at least 3 pixels brighter than −6 dB and six times the local sea background, more than 160 m offshore (ESA WorldCover 2021 water mask). Fixed structures (platforms, buoys, wrecks) seen in at least 60% of passes were removed. “Large” means a footprint above 25 pixels (10,000 m²). One pass (30 May, Sentinel-1D) was dropped as sensor clutter. Images in this report are shown at 60 m.

Optical. Sentinel-2 Level-2A from Element 84 Earth Search, true colour (bands 4-3-2), cloud cover under 15–20%. Places located with OpenStreetMap / Nominatim: Ramchah, Naghasheh, Larak, the Shajareh Tayyebbeh school.

News. Sources were gathered in a web search pass on 27 September 2026. Some sites blocked direct access and were read through search snippets or syndicated copies. Iranian state media figures are marked as such.

War, ceasefire, neighbours

- 2026 Iran war · Wikipedia · en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2026_Iran_war
- 2026 Iran war ceasefire · Wikipedia · en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2026_Iran_war_ceasefire
- US launches new attacks on Iran · Al Jazeera, 16 Jul · aljazeera.com
- US pauses attacks on Iran · NPR, 26 Jul · npr.org
- September 2026 US strikes on Iran · Wikipedia · en.wikipedia.org
- Iranian strikes on the UAE · Wikipedia · en.wikipedia.org
- 2026 Iranian strikes on Kuwait · Wikipedia · en.wikipedia.org

Strait and shipping

- IMF PortWatch · portwatch.imf.org
- Strait of Hormuz brief · Lloyd’s List Intelligence, 9 Sep · lloydslistintelligence.com
- 2026 Strait of Hormuz crisis · Wikipedia · en.wikipedia.org
- Mayuree Naree (2007) · Wikipedia · en.wikipedia.org
- Mayuree Naree runs aground on Qeshm · gCaptain, 27 Mar · gcaptain.com
- War-risk payout for Mayuree Naree · Marine Insight, 10 Aug · marineinsight.com

Oil off Qeshm

- Oil spill report · Iran International, 12 Aug · iranintl.com
- Gulf oil spills spread · Euronews, 14 Aug · euronews.com
- Reuters report on the slicks · Insurance Journal, 14 Aug · insurancejournal.com
- 3.2 ha of Qeshm coast contaminated · WANA (Iranian) · wanaen.com

Minab school

- 2026 Minab school attack · Wikipedia · en.wikipedia.org

- Deadly and unlawful US strike on school · Amnesty, 16 Mar · amnesty.org
- Was the attack a war crime? · HRW, 20 Apr · hrw.org
- UN report on Minab strike · TIME, 18 Sep · time.com

Coast, ports, fishermen

- Bandar Abbas flights resume · Iran International, 5 Jul · iranintl.com
- Bandar Abbas airport reopens · Middle East Eye, 15 Aug · middleeasteye.net
- Satellite images show war damage · Military.com, 17 Mar · military.com
- Southern Iran is being destroyed · New Lines, 27 Jul · newlinesmag.com
- Shahid Rajaee port idle · Iran International, 5 Sep · iranintl.com
- US airstrikes on civilian infrastructure · Drop Site, 13 Aug · dropsitenews.com
- 12 fishermen killed · Press TV (Iranian state media) · presstv.substack.com
- US destroys two Iranian boats · Marine Insight · marineinsight.com

Wedding strike, protests, economy

- 2026 Kuhestak wedding airstrike · Wikipedia · en.wikipedia.org
- Wedding party hit in Sirik · Al Jazeera, 2 Sep · aljazeera.com
- US military investigation · Axios, 4 Sep · axios.com
- What happened at the protests · Amnesty, 26 Jan · amnesty.org
- Inflation figures · Iran International, 26 Sep · iranintl.com
- Rial hits record low · Euronews, 2 Sep · euronews.com

Data

- Copernicus Sentinel-1 and Sentinel-2 data (ESA), via Microsoft Planetary Computer and Element 84 Earth Search
- ESA WorldCover 2021 · OpenStreetMap contributors